

KUOMBOKA

a film by J. Aldridge

PART ONE

As the water rises, the kingdom moves.
Five hundred years on the Zambezi—
His highness, Lubosi Imwiko II
The Litunga
leads his people to higher ground.

Boats festooned with elephants
Push upriver
A celebration of resilience
As homes flood below.

Warriors of the Nalikwanda
Wear red berets and row
Carrying the kingdom
Against the current
To safety, as the water rises.

cue: Home Town, by Witch

FADE IN:

The Zambezi River spreads out around us. Rich blue.

People line the river's edge, cheering and dancing. The king's barge passes by and the warriors, stone-faced, drive the procession forward with bamboo poles sunk down to the riverbed. Elephants cross just upstream.

This is the story of a people always on the brink, as the river moves.

CUT TO:

Three trucks of armed men drive across Liuwa Plain, guarding the kangoni herd from bushmeat traders... poachers. A spotter scans the horizon. Another watches the treeline. They'll follow like sheep dogs for most of the three-thousand kilometre migration. For now, as the herd rests for the night, so do the day watch.

PART TWO

Back in Limilunga, parliament meets. Ceremonial niceties end with a kneeling pledge to serve.

As the sun rises, business begins.

Red bereted guards watch through unglazed windows as guests seek an audience with the king. Locals mostly, but a few outsiders watch from the back—hoping to learn their part of each person's formal introduction. No one ever gets it right the first time but the ministers smile kindly, coaching each with whispered phonetics.

"Lumela. Libizo laka ki—"

CUT TO:

Walking across the courtyard, red clay crunches under foot.

The throne, rosewood with carved elephants for arms, sits in one end of the room. The other half's filled with four rows of folding chairs. The prime minister stands next to the throne and gestures for everyone to sit.

Litunga enters and guests, bearing gifts of fruit and fish, come forward with their requests. One by one, they trickle back out into the now harsh, midday sun.

The outsiders approach, bringing their gifts to the kingdom.

CUT TO:

People line the river's edge, fishing, washing, and drawing water. Children, thirsty from playing, wait for the filters to work rather than scooping handfuls from the river.

Nalikwanda return from guard, passing by the town well as the sun hangs low on the horizon. Soft lights glow from more doorways than normal.

"Lumela." A kid waves from the doorway.

That night, a fisherman pushes into the river and casts his net, illuminated by a soft electric glow.

PART THREE

On the outskirts of the kingdom, a day's walk north of Limilunga, lights click on and the workday begins. Hippos float in the distance as a group of children pick their way down amongst the reeds and cast their nets under the sunrise.

With the catch pulled ashore, water jugs are filled and filtered, then school begins.

The way back to Limilunga passes through cattle herds and pushed bicycles carrying rosewood bundles along a deeply rutted road.

cue: Khala My Friend, by Amanaz

Turn at the well and head east. From there, it's a nine hour drive back through Kafue to the airport in Lusaka.

An old land cruiser lurches to a stop in the middle of the one lane bridge. The driver points and everyone steps out to watch as elephants cross in the distance.

Roll credits and fade to black.